

Thinking Critically in the Age of Social Media



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Introduction

How misinformation, filters, and viral trends affect our ability to think clearly?

- We spend **4–5 hours daily** on social media.
- Fake news spreads **6x faster** than true news (MIT study, 2018).
- Algorithms feed us what we *like*, not what is *true*.

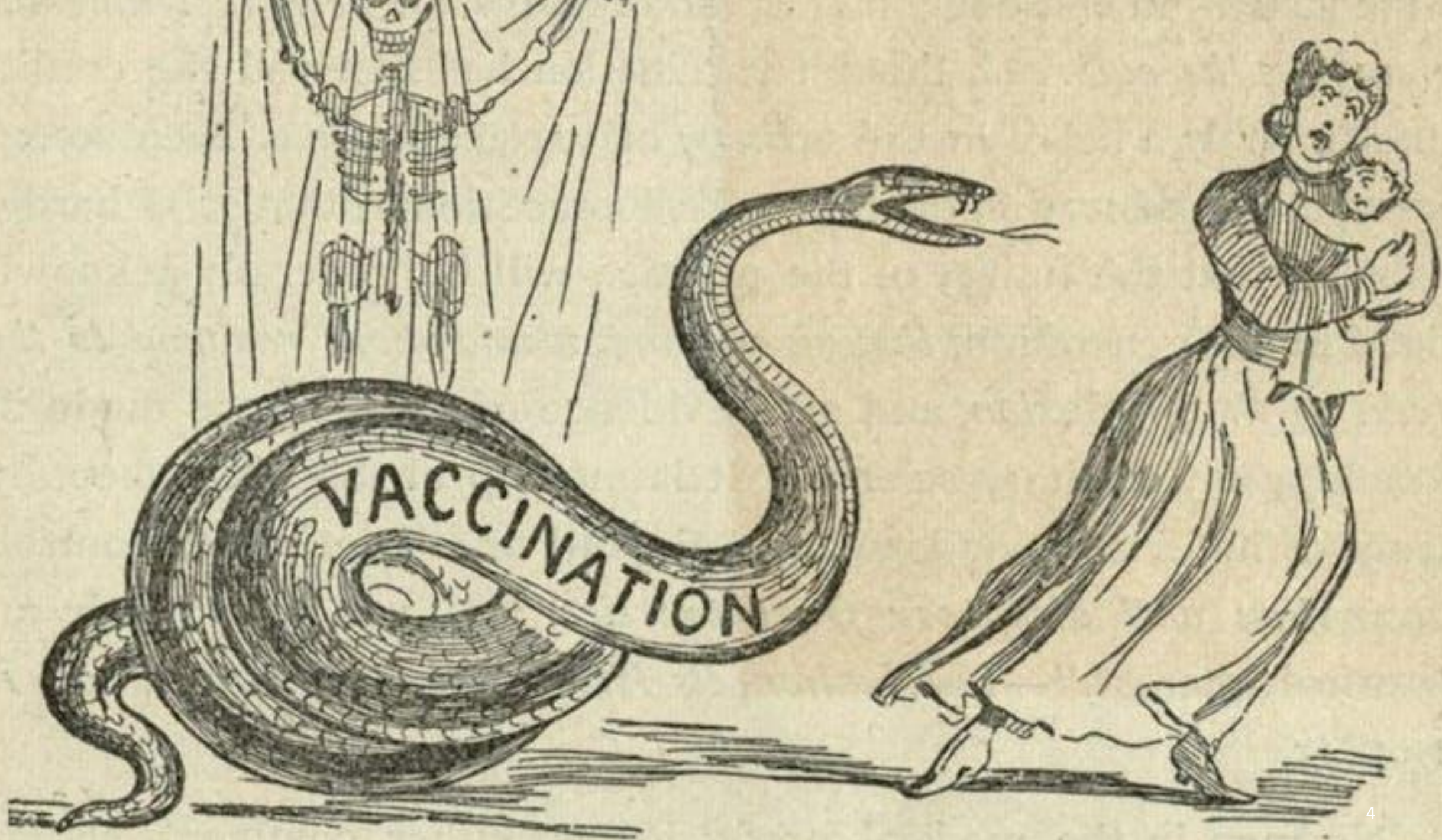


Fake News Examples

- Fake News:

- “NASA says the Earth will have 15 days of darkness!” (Shared in 2015 & 2017) Reality: NASA never said that totally made up.
- When COVID-19 spread globally, a viral post claimed that **5G mobile towers were spreading the coronavirus** people even started **burning telecom towers** in the UK and Netherlands.





Definitions

- **Misinformation:**

- False information that is held or spread, regardless of intent.

- **Disinformation:**

- False information that is spread with the intent to mislead.

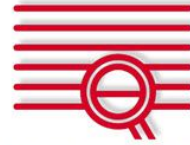


HOW TO SPOT FAKE NEWS



CONSIDER THE SOURCE

Click away from the story to investigate the site, its mission and its contact info.



READ BEYOND

Headlines can be outrageous in an effort to get clicks. What's the whole story?



CHECK THE AUTHOR

Do a quick search on the author. Are they credible? Are they real?



SUPPORTING SOURCES?

Click on those links. Determine if the info given actually supports the story.



CHECK THE DATE

Reposting old news stories doesn't mean they're relevant to current events.



IS IT A JOKE?

If it is too outlandish, it might be satire. Research the site and author to be sure.



CHECK YOUR BIASES

Consider if your own beliefs could affect your judgement.



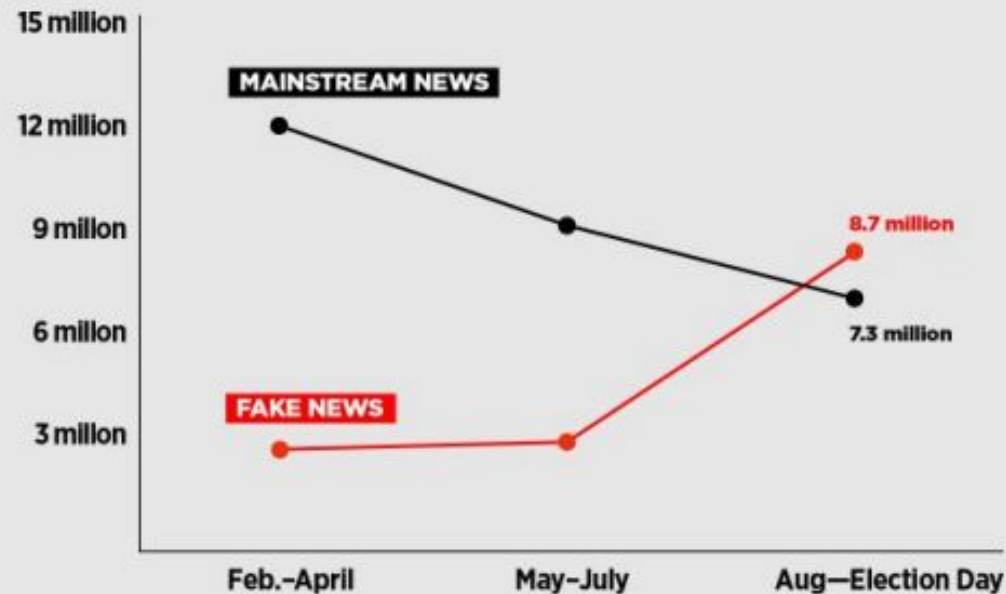
ASK THE EXPERTS

Ask a librarian, or consult a fact-checking site.

Fake and real news have about the same engagement on social media

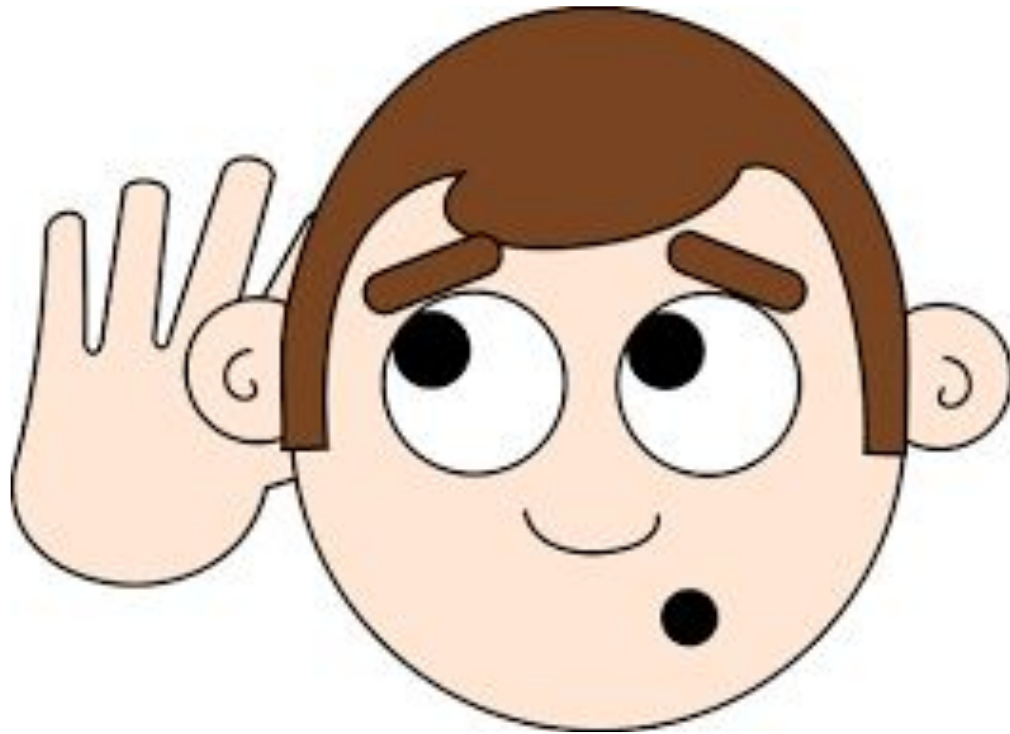
- this is 10% for real news
- but 40% for “fake news”

Total Facebook Engagements for Top 20 Election Stories



ENGAGEMENT REFERS TO THE TOTAL NUMBER OF SHARES, REACTIONS, AND COMMENTS FOR A PIECE OF CONTENT ON FACEBOOK SOURCE: FACEBOOK DATA VIA BUZZSUMO

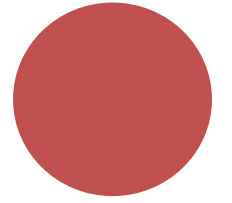
Spot the Fake News



- Twitter blocked in Pakistan permanently after protests.
- A politician's AI-generated video went viral showing a fake speech.
- Punjab Government to give free iPhones to university student.

The Need for Critical Thinking

- Question, analyze, interpret, evaluate, and determine the veracity of what you read, hear, say, or write.



Psychology Angle

Misinformation hijacks our **confirmation bias** we believe what fits our existing opinions. It reduces our ability to critically evaluate and increases emotional reactivity.

According to a 2023 **Pew Research Center** survey, **64% of adults** say fake news causes “a great deal of confusion about basic facts of current events.



Tips to Avoid Misinformation



2

Verify the source and date of the information.

Look up the information at the source to see if it was actually published there. Double-check the date of the article or info to make sure it's current and still accurate.

Tips to Avoid Misinformation



1

Pause and be skeptical about new information.

It's okay to be doubtful!
It's better to investigate
information to make sure
it's legit before spreading
it around.

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Tips to Avoid Misinformation



3

**Check to see if you
can tell who the
original author is.**

Find out who wrote the
information by looking up
the article or searching
for their name.

Tips to Avoid Misinformation



4

Search online for the information in other sources.

Look up the claim or information online to see if other news outlets or organizations are also saying similar things.

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Tips to Avoid Misinformation



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Watch out for info that triggers a strong emotional response.

Misinformation is often designed to make you feel angry, sad, scared, or just plain old upset.



- If it's viral, it's not always vital.
- So next time you scroll, pause. Ask who benefits from what I believe? Because clear thinking isn't automatic it's a choice.